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Arsenal did not win the Premier League in one glorious rush across a pitch. It arrived through a scoreline from elsewhere, through anxious eyes fixed on Bournemouth, through the strange quiet before relief finally broke.

Manchester City needed to win at Bournemouth on May 19 to keep the title race alive, but a 1-1 draw left Mikel Arteta's side four points clear with one match remaining. A day earlier, Arsenal had done its part with a tight 1-0 win over Burnley. Then it waited. For once, it ended kindly.

For a generation of Arsenal supporters, the league title had existed mostly as inheritance. They had heard the stories of Highbury, of Arsene Wenger's great sides, of Thierry Henry gliding through defenders and Patrick Vieira lifting the trophy, but their own memories were shaped by something else: late-season slips, Champions League exits, fourth-place jokes, anger outside the Emirates and the uneasy feeling that Arsenal had become a club always close to being itself again, but never quite there.

That is why this title carried more than celebration. It felt like a release.

For Arsenal, this was never only about a league title. It was about 22 years of carrying 2003-04 as both memory and burden. The Invincibles, with Vieira lifting the trophy and Henry in full flight, had given the club a season that seemed almost untouchable.

But it also became the final reference point for every Arsenal side that followed. The club won FA Cups and Community Shields after that, but the Premier League trophy kept moving further away.

The years in between were filled with beauty, frustration and reinvention. Wenger remained the defining figure long after the last

league title, but the later years of his reign carried the ache of teams that could still play beautifully but could no longer impose themselves over an entire season.

Unai Emery arrived in 2018 as the first major break from that era, but his stay lasted only 18 months. Freddie Ljungberg briefly held the side together before Arteta returned in December 2019.

With no senior managerial experience, Arteta's appointment looked risky. He won the FA Cup in his first season, but Arsenal finished eighth in successive campaigns, fell out of Europe and, at one point in 2021, looked far removed from the club that had once made Champions League qualification feel routine.

The rebuild was not romantic. It was severe. Pierre-Emerick Aubameyang moved on. The dressing room was reshaped. The squad became younger, harder and more controlled. Arteta did not simply try to restore Wenger's Arsenal; he built something sterner.

That is why this title feels different from the old Arsenal ideal. It was not always built on fluency. It was built on pressure, territory, structure and a refusal to let matches drift.

Arteta's Arsenal pressed high, guarded space carefully and became comfortable winning games that did not flatter the eye. The old accusation that Arsenal was too soft slowly disappeared. In its place came another: too mechanical, too set-piece heavy, too willing to win ugly.

The criticism reached its loudest point in March, when Arsenal's corner routines became a talking point across the league. Some called it unattractive. Others argued that set pieces were beginning to damage the spectacle. Arteta's answer was telling. He said he was upset that Arsenal did not score more from them. It sounded blunt, but it also revealed the edge of this team. Arsenal had stopped apologising for finding a way.

Nicolas Jover's set-piece work

became one of the season's decisive weapons. Arsenal scored 24 goals from set pieces in the league and 18 from corners, a Premier League record for a single season.

The winner against Burnley, headed in by Kai Havertz from Bukayo Saka's corner, was a perfect symbol of the campaign: nervous, narrow, rehearsed, decisive.

But it would be unfair to reduce Arsenal's title to corners alone. Declan Rice gave the team its engine and authority. Martin Zubimendi's arrival added control in midfield. Eberechi Eze brought invention and personality. Viktor Gyokeres, with his goals and presence, gave Arsenal the centre-forward profile it had long been chasing.

Saka, even through an injury-interrupted campaign, remained the player opponents feared most in the forward line. Leandro Trossard and Havertz gave Arteta the kind of decisive moments title-winning squads need beyond their obvious stars.

At the other end, Arsenal's title had its clearest foundation. David Raya won the Premier League Golden Glove for a third successive season, while Gabriel Magalhaes and William Saliba formed the core of the league's shrewdest defence. Gabriel gave Arsenal force in both boxes. Saliba gave it calm. Jurrien Timber, until injury interrupted his season, added aggression and balance. This was not a fragile Arsenal waiting to be bullied. It was a side built to survive bad days.

That mattered because the old label never fully disappeared. After three straight runner-up finishes, the word 'bottlers' followed Arsenal into every wobble. In 2022-23, City chased it down. In 2023-24, City edged it by two points. In 2024-25, Liverpool finished above it.

Each near miss hardened the question: did Arsenal have enough nerve when the season tightened? This time, the answer came not through swagger, but through resistance.